Lot of deliberation was done before launching the South Waziristan operation. TTP's Mehsud stronghold was encircled to stop the militants' supply lines and separate the Waziri chapter of the Taliban from the Mehsud affiliate. Earlier, three times, the army had gone into South Waziristan, but could not achieve the desired results. However, the army seemed determined to win this time. It was going to be a war that was both guerrilla in nature – the militants knew the terrain and had local support – and conventional in its goals. 'For the military, the goal is limited: to degrade and destroy these elements and not let them use South Waziristan as a sanctuary from which to spread terrorism in the rest of Pakistan,' said Rifaat Hussain, Quaid-i-Azam University, Islamabad. 'But for the TTP, it is a battle for survival. If they lose, the whole movement is finished.'

Most civilians fled the area of fighting in South Waziristan, enabling the army to use extensive air power against militants without fear of collateral damage. Pakistan Air Force fighter jets pounded the hideouts and compounds of TTP militants. ISPR reported that hundreds had been killed, injured and arrested. Rest were on the run looking for shelter (*The Nation*, 2009). However, this operation proved tougher than the one against the Swat TTP because the terrain is harsh and closer to the Afghan border and their numerical strength is more than the Swat TTP. However, one big consolation was that Pakistan's most wanted man, Baitullah Mehsud, was killed, though in a US drone attack (Lodhi, 2010). Nevertheless, this loss did not throw TTP in disarray, and Hakimullah Mehsud stepped in to lead it.

Meanwhile, the army entered into truce tactics with non-Mehsud militants. Maulvi Nazir and Hafiz Gul Bahadur entered into non-aggression pacts with the army and were promised money and reconstruction projects in exchange for their neutrality. The Haqqani network, led by former Afghan warlord Jalaluddin Haqqani – one of the most-wanted militants by the US, whose network had concentrated its efforts on attacking NATO forces in Afghanistan – was also expected to remain passive throughout the operation, military officials told TIME. Although this policy was criticised by many, the Pakistan Army spokesperson, Athar Abbas, defended these agreements. He asked, 'If you have to defeat the main serpent, would you like to isolate that from the others or deal with them all at once?' Prof. Rifaat Hussain, Quaid-i-Azam University, Islamabad, thought the tactic